

Definiteness in Central Kurdish: sources and outcomes

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Geoffrey Haig
University of Bamberg

Masoud Mohammadirad
Paris III Sorbonne

Research questions and objectives

- What is the nature of definiteness marking in Central Kurdish (CK)?
- What are the origins of definiteness marking in CK?
- To what extent is contemporary definiteness marking in CK shaped by:
 - (a) the nature of the source morphemes ('path dependency', cf. Christofaro 2014)
 - (b) universal functional constraints that shape the outcome of language change, yielding convergent systems regardless of origins (Haspelmath 2016)?

1 Definiteness

Universal and language-specific aspects

2 Data and methodology

Definiteness markers in Sorani

Data from the questionnaire

Data from naturalistic language data

4 Results

5 Conclusions

Definiteness

is a property that can be assigned to a NP in a particular discourse context.
A NP is considered definite if the following conditions are met:

The speaker:

(a) assumes that the referent of the NP is identifiable by the listener
(identifiability criterion);

(b) assumes that that the NP refers to all members of the intended set of referent(s)
(inclusiveness criterion)

(based on Lyons 1999)

The status of 'definite' is assigned to a NP with reference to a **particular knowledge frame**:

Global frames (independent of time and space)

the moon

the sun

Culture-specific frames

The Prime Minister

Local frames (setting-dependent):

the talk

the topic

the audience

Linguistic contexts for assigning definiteness (cf. Abbott 2004, among many others)

Anaphoric:

*A king had two children, a boy and a girl. One day, **the girl** was playing in **the garden** ...*

Associative/bridging:

***the garden** (knowledge frames: Kings live in palaces > palaces have gardens)*

Unique reference:

the moon

Via deictic elements:

this boring lecture ...

NP-internal (e.g. relative clause, possessor)

*Let me introduce you to [**the man** who got me interested in syntax] / [my **brother**].*

(note the problem of proper nouns; to be discussed later)

While definiteness as exemplified above is a **universal property of noun phrases, available in every language**, individual languages vary in the extent to which they signal definiteness through overt morphological means.

Around half the languages of the world have no overt morphological signalling of definiteness > definiteness is to some extent a morphological luxury, which languages can evidently dispense with (Becker 2019)

Definiteness in CK:

- No case, no gender (remnants in some dialects)
- (In)definiteness marked by affixes:

Forms for *pyāw* 'man'

	NO DETERMINER (BARE)	INDEFINITE	DEFINITE
SINGULAR	<i>pyāw</i>	<i>pyāw-ēk</i>	<i>pyāw-aka</i>
PLURAL	<i>pyāw</i>	<i>pyāw-ān</i>	<i>pyāw-ak-ān</i>

The K-suffix

(McCarus 2009: 613)

With demonstratives *am* 'this' / *aw* 'that man':

SG	<i>am / aw pyāw-a</i>
PL	<i>am / aw pyāw-ān-a</i>

Investigating the function of K-suffixes in CK

- Available literature suggests that they are definiteness markers, essentially comparable in function to e.g. the English definite article (Zahedi et al 2011)
- Good reason to doubt this assumption (see below)
- Systematic investigation based on (1) a questionnaire, and (2) original texts

The questionnaire

- Mini-narrative methodology (Haig 2018)
- Approx. 100 relevant items on the questionnaire, built into narratives presented in Persian (see below)
- Includes items that are
 - Anaphorically definite
 - Bridging definite
 - Proper nouns
 - Possessed nouns
 - with unique reference
 - Indefinite
- 20 speakers of CK from Iran

The questionnaire

- Six mini-narratives, originally composed in English, then translated into Persian
- Speakers are asked to provide a natural, unplanned, spoken translation into their own language
- The utterances are recorded, transcribed, and the target items (approx. 100) are coded
- Main dependent variable: presence vs. absence of a K-suffix
- 20 speakers of CK from Iran, also completed with speakers of Balochi, Luri and Esfahani Persian (Nourzaei 2019)

Narrative #1, pilot version (modified and extended in the final version)

When we went to the garden we saw a man and his son. The man was up a tree, picking apples. He threw the apples to his son. The boy put them in a basket. I said to the boy: "Please give me that basket!" He gave me the basket but I dropped it on the ground.

Human, singular, first mention

Human, singular, possessed

*When we went to the garden we saw **a man** and **his son**. The man was up a tree, picking apples. He threw **the apples** to his son. The boy put them in a basket. I said to the boy: "Please give me that basket!" He gave me **the basket** but I dropped it on the ground.*

Non-human, singular, anaphoric

Non-human, plural, anaphoric

Human, singular, first mention

Human, singular, possessed

ما وقتی رفتیم سر باغ یک مردی را با پسرش دیدیم. مرد بالای یک درخت بود و داشت سیب می‌چید.
سیبها را می‌انداخت پایین برای پسرش. پسر آنها را می‌گذاشت توی یک سبد. من به پسر گفتم: "آن
سبد را بده به من." او سبد را به من داد ولی من آن را انداختم زمین.

Non-human, singular, anaphoric

Non-human, plural, anaphoric

1	engl	obj.lang.token	def-suff	i-suff	pl	poss	dem
2	a man	pyaw-ēk		0	1	0	0
3	his son	kur-eke=y		1	0	0	1
4	the man	pyaw-eke		1	0	0	0
5	a tree	draxt-ēk		0	1	0	0
6	apples	sēw=ī		0	0	0	0
7	the apples	sēw-ek-ān=ī		1	0	1	0
8	his son	kur-eke-y		1	0	0	1
9	the boy	kur-eke=šī		1	0	0	1
10	a basket	sewetēyek		0	1	0	0
11	the boy	kur-eke=yim		1	0	0	0
12	that basket	ew sewetē		0	0	0	0
13	the basket	sewet-eke		1	0	0	0
14	the ground	xwer					
15	my brother	bray-eke=m		1	0	0	1
16	a teacher	mi'alim		0	0	0	0
17	a school	medrese-yē		0	1	0	0
18	Tehran	tehran		0	0	0	0
19	the director	modir-i medres-eke		0	0	0	1

RESULTS FROM QUESTIONNAIRE DATA (BEING FINISHED NOW)

K-suffixes in connected original narratives (preliminary)

- In the available spoken CK texts in (MacKenzie 1962, Öpengin 2016), K-suffixes are **generally used for notionally definite NPs**, as expected ...
- But **many anaphorically definite NPs lack the expected K-suffix**
- Difficult to reconcile with conventional view of definiteness marking, and not predictable from the questionnaire results
- Entirely ignored in the literature

Example 1

ew mindāley dew sundūqey
denēyn, serī lē dādexeyn
dew čomey dāwēyn bā āw bībā

deybā bo memleketēkī dīke
wiłā čūn le kin nejāřēkī
řerzī to bikem

sundūqekyān be durust kirdin dā
eger le hīč kö āwē nedā
mindāleyān de sundūqē hāwīšt
be čomēyān dādā āw birdī

We shall put this child in that coffer,
close the lid over him,
(and) throw it into this river so that
the water takes him away.

It will take him to another country.”
By God, they went to a carpenter.
Let me tell you.

They had a coffer built that would
not take in water from anywhere.
They threw the child into the coffer.
They left it in the river, (and) the
water took it.

(Mukri Kurdish, Öpengin 2016: 254-255)

Example 2: Tracing a highly salient referent through discourse:

nejāř ‘carpenter’

From a folktale (Mukri dialect, Öpengin 2016)

First mention: Existential: ‘there was **a carpenter** –INDEF’ (*nejāř –ēk*)

Second mention: Definite-marked: (*nejāř –eke*)

All subsequent mentions: Bare noun (*nejāř*)

Same pattern for other persistent human referents:

- **First mention:** N-INDEF (*N –ēk*)
- **(Second mention:)** Definite-marked: (*N –eke*)
- **All subsequent mentions:** Bare noun/demonstrative + noun

Examples from the texts include:

<i>feqē</i>	‘student’
<i>žin</i>	‘woman’
<i>kič</i>	‘girl’
<i>kūr</i>	‘boy’
<i>wazīr</i>	‘vizier’
<i>pāšā</i>	‘king’

Also one non-human example that patterns like this:

sēv ‘apple’ (but in this story it is an apple with magical properties ...)

Provisional conclusions

- Definiteness (anaphoric definiteness) is a necessary, but not a sufficient, condition for triggering definiteness marking with *-aka*.
- This may be linked to different conventions regarding **name-assignment** in Kurdish: speakers may confer the status of 'proper noun' to an item relatively flexibly in response to current discourse conditions: 'the act of naming' can be negotiated on the fly, depending on the speakers' common ground
- The distinction between definite expressions and proper nouns is fluid in CK
- Items singled out for 'proper noun' status may thus dispense with K-suffixes
- Added complication of the use of demonstratives and the use of the definiteness suffix *-e*

Is the referent singular, specific, indefinite?

YES

Use the indefinite singular suffix *-ēk*

NO

Is a **generic reference** intended?

NO

Are the contextual conditions such that it is worth assigning the referent a **name**?

NO

Use the definiteness suffix *-aka*
Or a demonstrative + N

YES

Use the bare noun

YES

THE REMAINING SLIDES ARE JUST NOTES AND CAN BE IGNORED

SOME FINAL GENERAL CONCLUSIONS ON 1-2 SLIDES ARE REQUIRED, will work on them tomorrow; WITH NOTES ON DIMINUTIVE ORIGINS

Key to understanding the system: the existence of the bare noun option

In English, singular count nouns must be realized with a determiner:

**pistol, *apple, *boy, *girl*

These are not grammatical NPs in English, even when used generically (ignoring the possibility of type shifts).

Kurdish has a 3-way choice for singular count nouns:

(a) bare N

(b) N-indef

(c) N-*aka*

Recall: bare nouns is the form for generic, non-specific, and for unique referents

Bare nouns:

Proper names, titles etc, derive their unique reference ('name') status from **global** knowledge frames:

<i>šār-ī silāmānī</i>	'Sulaimania City, the city of Sul.'
<i>māṇ-ī galāwēž</i>	'the month of Gelawezh'
<i>māṇ</i>	'the moon'
<i>rōž</i>	'the sun'
<i>qur'ān</i>	'the Qoran'
<i>Baydaa</i>	'Baghdad'
<i>zmān-ī kurdī</i>	'the Kurdish language '

Common nouns can derive 'name' status from **local** discourse context:

<i>feqē</i>	'student'
<i>žin</i>	'woman'
<i>kič</i>	'girl'
<i>kūr</i>	'boy'
<i>wazīr</i>	'vizier'
<i>pāšā</i>	'king'

3. Origins of definiteness marking in Sorani

1. No definiteness marking in Old or Middle Iranian
2. Absent in most contemporary Iranian languages, and in other dialects of Kurdish
3. How did it arise in Sorani?

The Greenberg Cycle (1978) for the grammaticalization of definiteness marking

- Origin of definiteness markers (articles) via **grammaticalization of demonstratives**
- The most widely-cited source of definiteness marking (Mulder & Carlier 2010)

DEIXIS-SENSITIVE		DISCOURSE-SENSITIVE		GRAMMAR-SENSITIVE
demonstrative	>	article	>	noun-class marker

The morpheme ordering paradox

Swedish:

bil-ar-na

car-PL-DEF

Sorani Kurdish:

jin-ak-ān

woman-DEF-PL

> Definiteness suffix in Sorani cannot have arisen through the grammaticalization of a demonstrative element

Origins of definiteness markers

“Even though the grammatical category of articles as such is far from being universal, the grammaticalization process that leads to its development exhibits cross-linguistic regularities: in the majority of cases, the definite article originates from a weakened demonstrative, mostly the distal demonstrative [...].”

De Mulder & Carlier (2011), see also Himmelmann’s “D-elements” (2001)

(but see now Pakendorf & Krivoschapkina 2014 for a case study of evaluative > definiteness, brought to my attention by Dejan Matić, p.c.)

Provisional conclusion (Haig, in press c.):

“For western Middle Iranian, a suffix *-ag* is noted as "one of the most productive" suffixes, creating nouns and adjectives (Durkin-Meisterernst 2014: 155). It is evidently related to the *-ka / -aka* complex of Old Iranian just discussed, and has a similarly varied functional spectrum (which may well be indicative of a hybrid origin). It could create adjectives, or add a sense of diminution or endearment to a noun, among diverse other functions noted by Durkin-Meisterernst (2014: 156-158). It also occurred in phonological variants *-ak* or *-k*.”

Endearment/familiarity > identifiability > definiteness

diminutive > definiteness marker

4. Path determinacy vs. universal functional constraints

(Christofaro 2014, Haspelmath 2016, among others)

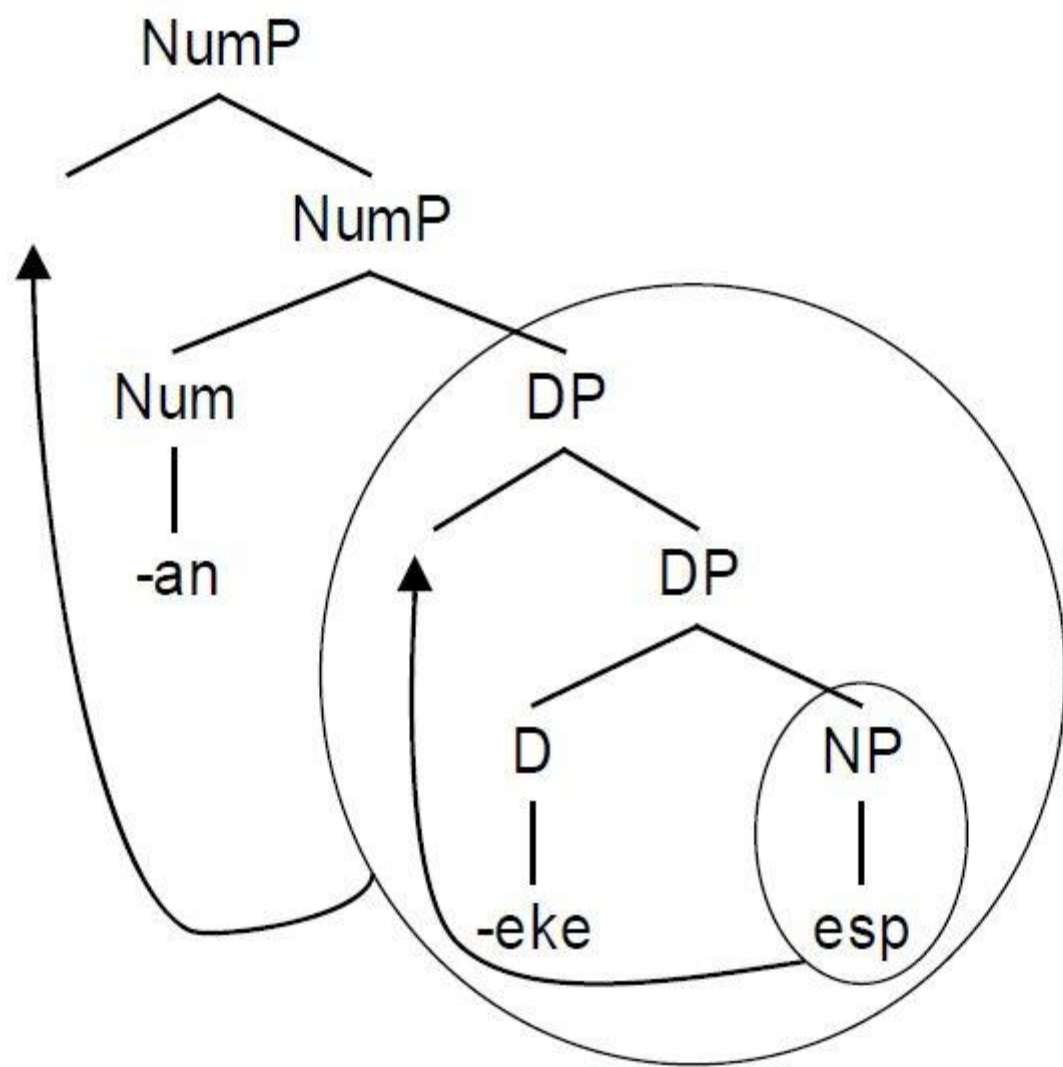
1. Is Sorani definiteness marking different from West European article-based definiteness because of its different origins?
2. Is Sorani definiteness marking similar to W.European article-based systems because definiteness marking is universally constrained by the same set of factors?

4. Conclusions / next steps

1. Multi-variate analysis of Sorani texts do determine what triggers presence vs. absence of – aka definiteness marking
2. Internal reconstruction of the historical emergence of definiteness marking in Sorani, based on a comparison with cognate markers in related West Iranian languages (Balochi, Luri, Laki, Bakhtiari etc.)

The Real Truth about optional definiteness in Sorani...

“In the data gathered, there was one example of a sentence in which the definite noun was not marked by any affix, i.e. it was used in a generic form. This is not correct; however, the **mistake** might have occurred by Kurds perhaps because **they have not noticed that they should use the noun in the definite state.**” [emphasis GH]
(Zahedi et al 2011: 145)



Bare form is used for:

- Generic
- non-specific reference (number-neutral)
- uniquely identifiable items (proper names, but see below)

Example 2: Non-human referent: *dargā* ‘door’

Narrative, one speaker

Associative setting: *... ū qawānī ‘abdulwahābmān gö lē girt - hatā hātīnawa*
 ‘... we would listen to records of Abdulwehab until we came back’

#	FORM	TRANSLATION / COMMENTS
1	door-DEF	the door (because ‘come back’ implies: to one’s house)
[intervening text of some 50 words]		
2	door	knocked on the (same) door again
3	door-DEF	the door of the house
4	door-DEF	the door
5	door-DEF	open the door for me!
6	door-DEF	they opened the door for me

Bare nouns:

Generics:

wafr spīya ‘**snow** is white’

Non-specific reference:

‘He would sell **melons**’

Proper names, titles etc:

<i>šār-ī silāmānī</i>	‘Sulaimania City, the city of Sul.’
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